



Columbus Ball Hockey League

Official Rule Book

*Based on the USA Ball Hockey Official Rule Book (Rev. 07.06.2021)
with CBHL-Specific Amendments*

★ NBHL rules printed with a gold star supersede the USA Ball Hockey rule book in all cases.

CODES OF CONDUCT

USA Ball Hockey provides the foundation for the sport of street and ball hockey in America. We strive to empower players and coaches with opportunity to participate in a game that encourages work ethic, leadership, sportsmanship, and mentorship. USABH aspires to develop coaches, players, officials, programs, and facilities. All USABH players, coaches, officials, fans, and associates shall promote the sport with pride, dignity, and respect towards all individuals.

Administrator's Code of Conduct

- Follow the rules and regulations of USA Ball Hockey and your association.
- Support programs that train and educate players, coaches, parents, officials and volunteers.
- Promote and publicize your programs; seek out financial support when possible.
- Communicate with parents by holding orientation meetings and remaining available throughout the season.
- Work to provide programs that encompass fairness and promote fair play and sportsmanship.
- Recruit volunteers, including coaches, who demonstrate qualities conducive to being role models.
- Encourage coaches and officials to attend USA Ball Hockey clinics when available.
- Make every possible attempt to provide everyone, at all skill levels, with a place to play.
- Read and be familiar with the contents of this official playing rules document.

Coaches' Code of Conduct

- Care more about the player than winning a game.
- Be a positive role model to all of your players.
- Be generous with praise when deserved; be consistent, honest, fair and just.
- Never verbally or physically abuse others, particularly a player or official.
- Organize practices that are fun and challenging. Familiarize yourself with the rules, techniques and strategies.
- Maintain an open line of communication with your players' parents.
- Be concerned with the overall development of your players.

On-Rink Officials' Code of Conduct

- Act in a professional and businesslike manner at all times.
- Provide a safe and sportsmanlike environment for proper display of skills.
- Know all playing rules, their interpretations and their proper application.
- Be fair and impartial at all times.
- Use honesty and integrity when answering questions.
- Admit your mistakes when you make them.
- Dedicate yourself to personal improvement and maintenance of officiating skills.

Player's Code of Conduct

- Play for fun but work hard to improve your skills.
- Be a team player and get along with your teammates.
- Learn teamwork, sportsmanship and discipline.
- Always be a good sport.
- Respect your coach, teammates, parents, opponents and officials in public or in private.
- Never argue with an official's decision.

Spectator's Code of Conduct

- Display good sportsmanship. Always respect players, coaches and officials.

- Cheer good plays of all participants; avoid booing opponents.
- Help provide a safe and fun environment.
- Support the referees and coaches by trusting their judgment and integrity.
- Respect buildings and locker rooms as private areas for players, coaches and officials.

SECTION ONE — THE RINK

Rule 1 — Rink

Ball Hockey shall be played on an area called a 'Rink'. The playing surface shall be comprised of one of the following:

- Smoothed or painted concrete.
- Blacktop / asphalt.
- Plastic modular sports flooring — legality is at the determination of a USA Ball Hockey Certified Official.

Rule 2 — Rink Dimensions

In order to support a game whereby each team has 5 runners and 1 goaltender, the dimensions of the rink shall be no less than 160 ft. long and 75 ft. wide. Rink dimensions measuring less than those specified shall not be considered official for the purposes of tournament play. The corners shall be rounded in the arc of a circle with a radius between 25 and 30 feet.

The rink shall be enclosed by boards no more than 4 ft. and no less than 3 ft. 4 in. in height, measured from the floor surface. The surface of the boards facing the floor shall be white and free from obstructions. The base plate, of a maximum height of 12 in., shall be light in color.

Rule 3 — Division of Floor Surface

The rink shall be divided into zones as closely to standard specification as reasonably possible, including a neutral zone, two end zones, and designated face-off spots and circles.

Rule 4 — Goal Posts and Net

The goal net shall be 72 inches wide × 48 inches high × 24 inches deep at the base. The frame is painted red. Goals are to be held in place using breakaway anchors such as pins or magnets.

Rule 5 — Goal Crease

A goal crease shall be marked in front of each goal by a colored line 2 inches in width. The recommended crease extends 10–12 inches from the outside of each goal post, with a line 5 feet in length drawn at right angles to the goal line, joined at the top. The interior of the crease should be distinctly colored.

Rule 6 — Center Floor Spot and Circle

A colored spot 12 in. in diameter shall be marked exactly at the center of the rink. A circular line 2 in. wide, with a radius of 15 ft., shall be drawn around this spot.

Rule 7 — Face-Off Spots — Neutral Zone

Two colored spots 2 ft. in diameter shall be marked in the neutral zone, 5 ft. from each blue line and equidistant from the boards, with parallel lines 3 in. from the top and bottom of each spot.

Rule 8 — End Zone Face-Off Spots and Circles

In both end zones, face-off spots 2 ft. in diameter and circles with a 15 ft. radius shall be marked on the floor. The face-off spots shall be located 20 ft. from each goal line and 22 ft. on both sides of the center line. All lines shall be 2 in. wide.

Rule 9 — Players' Bench

Each rink shall have a players' bench accommodating at least sixteen players, located alongside the floor in the neutral zone near center. Only players in uniform and a maximum of five team officials may occupy the bench. Coaches and team officials are restricted to the length of the bench area during play.

Rule 10 — Penalty Bench

Each rink shall have a penalty bench located on the opposite side of the rink from the players' bench, or at least 20 ft. from either bench. There shall be two separate penalty boxes, designated 'Home' and 'Visitor', with adequate physical separation between opposing players.

Rule 11 — Referee's Crease

A colored semicircle 2 in. wide, with a 10 ft. radius, shall be marked on the floor immediately in front of the Penalty Timekeeper's seat.

Rule 12 — Signal and Timing Devices

Each rink shall have a suitable sound system and a visible game clock so that spectators, players, and game officials may be accurately informed of the time remaining.

SECTION TWO — TEAMS

Rule 13 — Composition of Team

A team shall have no more than six players on the floor at any one time: Goaltender, Right Defense, Left Defense, Center, Right Wing, and Left Wing. Each player shall wear an individual number, a minimum of 6 inches in height, on the back of their jersey.

Rule 14 — Players in Uniform

Each team shall be entitled to a maximum of 22 players in uniform, including two goaltenders. A minimum of five eligible players on each team shall be necessary to start the game. Before the start of the game, the Official in charge of each team shall provide the Referee or Official Scorer with a list of names and numbers of players and goaltenders.

Registered goaltenders may only play as goaltenders. When a goaltender is replaced, they must be replaced with another goaltender, except in cases of injury where no backup is available — in which case the team may play with six runners.

Rule 15 — Captain of the Team

Each team may appoint a Captain and up to three Alternate Captains. The Captain wears the letter 'C' and Alternate Captains wear 'A' in a conspicuous position on the front of their sweater in a contrasting color approximately 3 in. in height.

Only a Captain or Alternate Captain on the floor may ask the Referee for the interpretation of any rule. A Minor Penalty for delay of game shall be assessed to any Captain or Alternate Captain who leaves the bench to discuss rule interpretations with the Referee.

Rule 16 — Change of Players

Players may be changed at any time from the players' bench, provided the player leaving the floor is within 5 ft. of the bench and out of play before any change is made. A Bench Minor Penalty shall be assessed for violations of this rule. In the last two minutes of regular playing time, or anytime in overtime, deliberate illegal substitution results in a Penalty Shot.

Rule 17 — Injured Players

When a player is injured, they must be replaced by a substitute and play must continue without teams leaving the floor. A player bleeding or covered in blood must leave the rink for treatment and may only return once the injury is properly closed and blood is removed from player and equipment.

SECTION THREE — EQUIPMENT

Rule 18 — Sticks

Sticks may be made of wood, fiberglass, aluminum, or any other material approved by the Rules & Competition Committee. They must not have any projections, pockets, or netting.

Maximum stick dimensions: 63 in. from heel to end of shaft; 12.5 in. from heel to end of blade; blade width 2–3 in. Goaltender's stick: max 55 in. shaft; 15.5 in. blade length; blade width 3–3.5 in. (max 4.5 in. at heel); shaft extension max 26 in. from heel at 3–3.5 in. width. Sticks may be wrapped with any color tape.

Rule 19 — Footwear

Hockey footwear must be of an approved design. Athletic-type footwear such as running shoes, cross trainers, trail runners, and tennis shoes is permitted. Goaltenders may wear footwear offering hard-shell toe and foot protection. Any footwear called into question is subject to Referee approval.

Rule 20 — Goaltending Equipment

All goaltender equipment must be constructed solely for the purpose of protection and must not give undue assistance in keeping goal. Blocker glove: max 8 in. wide, 16 in. long. Catching glove: max 4 in. base width, 8 in. length, 16 in. from base top to edge of webbing. Leg pads: max 12 in. wide as worn. Ball foil (plastic piece at bottom of pads) is illegal.

Goaltenders must wear an approved protective mask that protects the entire face, front and sides of the head, and the back of the head.

Rule 21 — Protective Equipment

All protective equipment, except gloves, head gear, shin guards, and goaltender leg pads, must be worn under the uniform. All players, including goaltenders, shall wear a UL-approved hockey helmet while on the floor. Players under 18 must also wear a full facial guard. Protective gloves are mandatory for all players.

Rule 22 — Dangerous Equipment

The use of pads, protectors, or sticks likely to cause injury is prohibited. All elbow pads must have a soft protective covering of sponge, rubber, or similar material at least ½ in. thick. The use of supplemental oxygen is prohibited. The Referee may prohibit any equipment deemed dangerous.

Rule 23 — Measurement of Equipment

Measurement of any equipment (sticks, goaltender pads and gloves) shall be carried out immediately when requested by a team through the Captain. If the complaint is not sustained, a Bench Minor Penalty is assessed to the challenging team. Only one measurement per stoppage of play. No goal shall be disallowed as a result of any measurement following a goal.

Rule 24 — Ball

The ball shall be made of plastic or other approved material. It shall be 3 inches in diameter and weigh between 5.5 and 6 ounces. Color will vary.

SECTION FOUR — OFFICIALS

Rule 25 — Appointment of Officials

It is highly recommended that each game have a Game Timekeeper, an Official Scorer, and two Referees. The Timekeeper may serve as Official Scorer when necessary. Referees must be certified by the Rules & Competition Committee prior to officiating. All Referees and Off-floor Officials shall be treated with courtesy by players and team officials. A Referee shall have full authority and the final decision in all matters under dispute.

Rule 26 — Referees

Referees shall wear black trousers or shorts and a black-and-white striped sweater. All Referees are to wear a black hockey helmet with chin strap properly fastened. Elbow pads, shin pads, knee protection, and a half-shield visor are recommended. If appointed Referees are prevented from appearing, the Managers or Coaches shall agree on replacement Referees. All replacement Referees shall act in accordance with the rules in this rulebook.

Rule 27 — Referee Duties

The Referee shall see that teams are called to the floor at the appointed time, check the goal nets and floor markings before the game, check player equipment, assess all penalties as prescribed by the rules, stop play for any infraction, and give the final decision on disputed goals. After each game, the Referee shall check and sign the Official Game Report.

Rule 28 — Official Scorer

The Official Scorer shall gather team rosters before the game, record all goals scored and assists, keep a record of all penalties assessed, and at completion of the game sign the Official Game Report and forward it to the Tournament Director. The Official Scorer shall advise the Referee when a player has received their second Misconduct or third penalty of any kind during the same game.

Rule 29 — Game Timekeeper

The Game Timekeeper shall record the start and finish time of each game and all actual playing time. They shall signal the Referee for the commencement of each game and period. In the event of any dispute regarding time, the matter shall be referred to the Referee in charge whose decision shall be final.

Rule 30 — Penalty Timekeeper

If a Penalty Timekeeper is used, they shall keep a correct record of all penalties assessed, including names, infractions, durations, and times assessed. If a player leaves the penalty bench before their time has elapsed, the Penalty Timekeeper shall note the time and signal the Referee.

Rule 31 — Goal Judges

When Goal Judges are used, they shall be stationed behind each goal outside the playing surface. Goal Judges shall confer with the Referee to determine if a goal was scored when requested. No team challenges of a goal are permitted.

SECTION FIVE — PLAYING RULES

Rule 32 — Ball Out of Bounds

When the ball goes outside the playing area or strikes obstacles above the playing surface (except side boards, glass, or netting), play shall be stopped. A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any player who deliberately shoots, bats, or throws the ball outside the playing surface. A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to a goaltender who deliberately drops or throws the ball onto the goal netting to cause a stoppage.

Rule 33 — Ball Out of Sight / Illegal Ball

At any time the Referee loses sight of the ball, play shall be stopped. If while play is in progress a second ball appears, play shall immediately be stopped. Face-off shall be in the zone where the legal ball was last in possession.

Rule 34 — Ball Striking Official

Play shall not be stopped if the ball touches an Official anywhere on the rink, except when the ball is deflected directly off an Official into the goal or out of the playing area. If the ball deflects off a Referee directly into a goal net, the play is stopped and no goal is awarded.

Rule 35 — Broken Sticks

A player whose stick is broken may participate in the game provided the broken stick is dropped immediately. A player may only receive another stick at their own players' bench or from a teammate on the floor. A goaltender who breaks or loses their stick may use a player's stick until the next stoppage of play. A goaltender may not go to the players' bench during a stoppage for a replacement stick.

Rule 36 — Clearing (Icing) the Ball

Should any player, equal or superior in numerical strength to the opposing team, shoot, bat, or deflect the ball from behind the designated clearing line of their own half of the floor beyond the goal line of the opposing team, play shall be stopped and the ball faced off at the end zone face-off spot of the offending team.

★ **NBHL RULE** Icing line: Red line used for Tier 1, 2, and 3 play.

★ **NBHL RULE** No line change on icing. If a timeout is called following an icing, line changes may not occur for the defensive team.

★ **NBHL RULE** The team in the offensive zone for an icing face-off may choose which dot the face-off is taken on.

★ **CBHL RULE** CBHL Icing Definition: Icing occurs when a player shoots, bats with the hand or stick, or deflects the ball over the defensive zone blue line and the opposing team's goal line, in that order, and the ball remains untouched without scoring a goal. This definition supersedes the NBHL icing line rule above.

The clearing infraction shall NOT be called when: the ball is touched by any part of an opposing player's stick or feet; the ball has touched the goaltender at any time before crossing the goal line; the goaltender leaves their crease to play the ball; or, in the Referee's opinion, an opposing player could have played the ball but chose not to.

Rule 37 — Face-Offs

A face-off shall take place when the Referee drops the ball between the sticks of the players facing off. Players shall stand squarely facing their opponent's end, approximately one stick length apart, with the full blade of the stick flat on the floor. All other players must be outside the circles or at least 15 ft. from

the face-off players. The visiting team player shall place their stick first. The ball must first hit the floor before players may play it.

Face-offs at the center face-off spot occur only: at the start of each period, following the scoring of a goal, or following premature goaltender substitution. A team committing a face-off infraction may have their face-off player ejected and replaced.

★ **NBHL RULE** The team in the offensive zone for a ball-out-of-rink face-off may choose which dot the face-off is taken on.

Rule 38 — Falling on the Ball

A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any player (except a goaltender) who deliberately falls on or gathers the ball into their body. A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to a goaltender who holds the ball against the goal or boards, or who falls on or gathers the ball while entirely outside their crease. A Penalty Shot shall be awarded when a defending player (except the goaltender) deliberately falls on the ball or gathers it within the goal crease.

Rule 39 — Goals and Assists

A goal shall be scored when the entire ball has legally passed between the goal posts, below the crossbar, and completely across the goal line. A goal shall NOT be allowed if the ball was directed into the net by a distinct kicking motion by an attacking player, or deliberately directed by any part of the attacking player's hand or body, or if it deflects off a Referee. Not more than two assists shall be credited on any one goal.

Rule 40 — Hand Pass

A player may stop or bat the ball in the air with an open hand or push it along the floor, unless they direct it to a teammate in the neutral or attacking zone — in which case play is stopped.

★ **NBHL RULE** Defensive zone hand pass is permitted, provided the hand pass originates AND ends below the blue line.

Rule 41 — Handling the Ball

Play shall be stopped if any player closes their hand on the ball and gains an advantage. A Minor Penalty shall be assessed for deliberately holding the ball against the boards or goal, deliberately holding the ball as a goaltender, or picking up the ball from the floor as a non-goaltender. A Penalty Shot shall be awarded if a defending player picks up the ball from the floor while in the goal crease.

Rule 42 — Interference by Spectators

The Referee shall stop play if a player is being held or interfered with by a spectator. Any player who physically interferes with a spectator shall be assessed a Game Misconduct Penalty.

Rule 43 — Kicking the Ball

Kicking the ball is permitted in all zones. However, a goal scored as the result of the ball being kicked by an attacking player and entering the goal directly — or after deflecting off any player including the goalkeeper — shall not be allowed. Intent and a distinct kicking motion must be present for this rule to apply.

Rule 44 — Off-Sides

Players of the attacking team must not precede the ball into the attacking zone. A 'Floating Blue Line' applies in Ball Hockey: once the attacking team legally crosses the opponent's blue line with the ball, the blue line is eliminated and the attacking zone extends from the center line in. The position of the player's feet (not the stick) is the determining factor. A player is off-side when both feet are completely over the outer edge of the blue line.

A delayed off-side signal shall be raised by the Referee when the attacking team precedes the ball into the attacking zone; the off-side shall be nullified if the defending team carries the ball to the neutral zone, or all attacking players clear the attacking zone by making foot contact with the blue line.

Rule 45 — Refusing to Start Play

If a team fails to return to the floor or start play within 1 minute after being ordered to do so, a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to the Coach for Delay of Game. If this infraction occurs in the last two minutes of regulation or anytime in overtime, a Penalty Shot shall also be awarded. A second refusal in the same game results in the game being officially suspended.

Rule 46 — Start of Game and Periods

The game shall commence at the scheduled time with a face-off at center. At the end of each period, all players must remain on their respective players' or penalty bench until directed off by the Referee. Failure to comply results in a Bench Minor Penalty.

★ **NBHL RULE** Game Starts — Lateness Penalties: If a team is 5 minutes late to start a game, they will be given a Minor Penalty for delay of game. If a team is 10 minutes late to start a game, they forfeit.

Rule 47 — Tied Game / Overtime

If at the end of regulation time the score is tied and overtime is to be played, teams change ends, and the ball is faced off at center with sudden-victory overtime.

★ **NBHL RULE** OT Regular Season: 3-minute stopping clock period, 3-on-3 play. Teams switch sides for overtime.

★ **NBHL RULE** OT Playoffs: Continuous 10-minute, 5-on-5 overtime.

★ **NBHL RULE** Shootout (if required after OT): 3 shooters per team. If tied after 3 shooters, any player may shoot any number of times until the game is won. Both goalies defend from the same net; officials choose which end. A coin flip determines who has the right to choose who shoots first.

★ **CBHL RULE** CBHL Overtime: If a game is tied at the end of regulation, one sudden death overtime period will be played. Overtime is 3-on-3 with a running clock for a maximum of 3 minutes. The first team to score wins the game immediately.

★ **CBHL RULE** CBHL Shootout — Round 1: If the game remains tied after overtime, a shootout will be held. Each team selects 3 different players to shoot, one shot each. The team with the most goals after all 3 shooters have gone wins the game.

★ **CBHL RULE** CBHL Shootout — Sudden Death Rounds: If still tied after Round 1, the shootout continues in sudden death rounds. Any player on the team may shoot, including players who were in the first three shooters. A player may shoot as many times as needed until the game is won.

Rule 48 — Time of Game

Three periods of regulation playing time with a 1-minute intermission between each period.

★ **NBHL RULE** Games will consist of three 10-minute stopping clock periods with 5-on-5 play.

★ **NBHL RULE** Mercy Rule: The clock runs continuously at a 6-goal differential. The game ends automatically at an 8-goal differential.

Rule 49 — Time-Outs

Each team may have one 30-second time-out per regulation game. All players, including goaltenders, may go to their respective benches during the time-out. Time-outs are not permitted at the beginning of a period. The player requesting time-out must be on the floor.

★ **NBHL RULE** One 30-second timeout per team, per game. Teams do NOT receive an additional timeout for overtime.

★ **NBHL RULE** Teams may only call a timeout for injury with less than 5 minutes left in a game that has a 6-or-more goal differential.

SECTION SIX — PENALTY TYPES

Penalties are served in actual playing time and are divided into the following classes: Minor Penalties, Bench Minor Penalties, Major Penalties, Misconduct Penalties, Game Misconduct Penalties, Gross Misconduct Penalties, Match Penalties, and Penalty Shots.

Any player or team official may be assessed penalties at any time before, during, or after a game. Any player (including the goaltender) shall be ejected from the game if they receive 3 penalties of any kind in the game.

Rule 51 — Minor Penalties

For a Minor Penalty, the offending player (except a goaltender) shall be ruled off the floor for the designated period; no substitute is permitted. If the penalized player is injured, another player designated by the Coach or Captain must serve the penalty. If a goal is scored against a short-handed team, the first Minor Penalty shall automatically terminate.

★ **NBHL RULE** Minor Penalties are 1 minute and 30 seconds.

★ **NBHL RULE** 3 minor penalties result in an ejection.

★ **NBHL RULE** Coincidental penalties keep gameplay at 5-on-5. If penalties occur on the same whistle but from different plays, gameplay goes to 4-on-4.

Rule 52 — Bench Minor Penalties

A Bench Minor Penalty requires the penalized team to play a player short for a period equal to that of a Minor Penalty. If the guilty player is identified, that player shall serve the penalty; otherwise, the Coach designates any player on the floor at the time of the infraction.

Rule 53 — Major Penalties

For all Major Penalties, the offending player shall be assessed a Game Misconduct Penalty and the team shall be short-handed for the designated time; no substitute is permitted. The offending player shall be ordered to the dressing room for the remainder of the game and reported to the Rules & Competition Committee for review.

★ **NBHL RULE** Major Penalties are 4 minutes.

Rule 54 — Misconduct Penalties

A player incurring a Misconduct Penalty shall be ruled off the floor for the designated period; a substitute is permitted immediately. A Misconduct Penalty shall be assessed to any player who: uses obscene, profane, or abusive language or gestures; persists in disputing or shows disrespect for an official's ruling; or intentionally knocks the ball out of reach of a Referee. A second Misconduct Penalty in the same game results in an automatic Game Misconduct Penalty.

★ **NBHL RULE** Misconduct Penalties are 5 minutes.

Rule 55 — Game Misconduct Penalties

Any player incurring a Game Misconduct Penalty shall be suspended for the remainder of the game; a substitute is permitted immediately. Any player or team official incurring a Game Misconduct Penalty shall be reported to the Rules & Competition Committee for review.

Rule 56 — Gross Misconduct Penalties

Any player incurring a Gross Misconduct Penalty shall be suspended for the remainder of the game and reported to the Rules & Competition Committee for review. A substitute is permitted immediately. Gross Misconduct Penalties include, but are not limited to, using racial or ethnic slurs, biting or spitting on another person, deliberately inflicting physical harm to a Game or Team Official, or behaving in any manner which is critically detrimental to the game.

Rule 57 — Match Penalties

Any player or team official incurring a Match Penalty shall be ordered to leave the playing area immediately for the balance of the game and shall not be permitted to participate in any further games until their case has been dealt with by the Rules & Competition Committee. The offending player's team shall send a player to the penalty box for 5 minutes.

Rule 58 — Penalty Shot

Any infraction calling for a Penalty Shot shall result in: the ball being placed at the center face-off spot; the fouled player taking the shot upon the Referee's signal; the ball being kept in motion toward the opponent's goal line; no goal scored on a rebound. The goaltender must remain in the goal crease until the designated player touches the ball at center. The game clock shall be paused for the entire penalty shot.

★ **NBHL RULE** Any delay of game penalty committed during the final 1:30 of the 3rd period or the final 1:30 of overtime will result in an automatic penalty shot.

Rule 59 — Calling of Penalties

If a player on the team in possession of the ball commits an infraction, the Referee shall blow the whistle immediately. If a player on the team NOT in possession commits an infraction, the Referee shall signal a delayed penalty (arm raised) and blow the whistle when the offending team gains possession. If the non-offending team scores before the whistle, the goal is allowed and a Minor Penalty shall not be assessed.

Rule 60 — Delayed Penalties

If a third player of any team is penalized while two players of the same team are already serving penalties, the third player's penalty time shall not commence until one of the two earlier penalties has elapsed. The third player must proceed to the penalty bench immediately but shall be replaced by a substitute on the floor.

Rule 61 — Goaltender Penalties

A goaltender shall not be sent to the penalty bench for a Minor Penalty infraction; the penalty shall be served by a designated teammate on the playing surface at the time of the infraction. When a goaltender incurs a Major Penalty, Game Misconduct, Gross Misconduct, or Match Penalty, a substitute goaltender or teammate shall take the position and shall be allowed 5 minutes to put on full goaltender equipment.

Rule 62 — Awarded Goals

A goal will be awarded to the attacking team when the opposing team has removed their goaltender and an attacking player on a breakaway is interfered with by an illegally entered player, or any stick or object is thrown by the defending team, or the puck carrier is fouled from behind. A goal will also be awarded when a defending player picks up the ball with their hand from the crease, or the goal is deliberately dislodged to prevent an obvious goal.

SECTION SEVEN — PENALTY INFRACTIONS

Rule 63 — Attempt to Injure

A Match Penalty shall be assessed to any player or team official who deliberately attempts to or deliberately injures an opponent, Official, Team Official, or spectator. A player who pulls an opponent's hair or grabs the facial protector or helmet to inflict injury shall be assessed a Match Penalty.

Rule 64 — Boarding / Body Checking

A Minor Penalty or, at the Referee's discretion, a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who body checks an opponent causing them to be thrown violently into the boards, or who intentionally body checks, bumps, shoves, or pushes any opposing player.

Rule 65 — Butt-Ending

A Major Penalty, Game Misconduct, and Gross Misconduct Penalty shall be assessed to any player who uses the butt end of their stick to impede, jab, or injure an opponent.

Rule 66 — Charging

A Minor Penalty or, at the Referee's discretion, a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who runs or jumps into or charges an opponent. If more than two steps or strides are taken, it shall be considered a charge. A Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed for charging or making unnecessary contact with a goaltender in their crease.

Rule 67 — Cross-Checking

A Minor Penalty or, at the Referee's discretion, a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who cross-checks an opponent. Any player who strikes an opponent above the shoulders with a cross-check, or cross-checks a goaltender in the crease, or injures an opponent via cross-check shall receive a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct.

Rule 68 — Delay of Game

A Bench Minor Penalty shall be assessed to a team which deliberately delays the game. A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any goaltender who deliberately shoots or bats the ball out of the playing surface. A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any player who delays the game for equipment adjustment — the player must leave the floor and a substitute enters.

★ **NBHL RULE** Any delay of game penalty committed during the final 1:30 of the 3rd period or the final 1:30 of overtime will result in an automatic penalty shot.

Rule 69 — Diving

A Minor Penalty for Unsportsmanlike Conduct shall be imposed on a player who attempts to draw a penalty by diving. This penalty may be assessed with or without a foul to the opposing team.

Rule 70 — Elbowing

A Minor Penalty or, at the Referee's discretion, a Major Penalty shall be imposed on any player who uses their elbow to foul an opponent. An inadvertent elbow is a Minor Penalty; an intentional elbow is a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct.

Rule 71 — Fighting

A Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who fights with an opposing player. The identified instigator or aggressor shall also receive a Minor Penalty. Any player who retaliates with a punch or attempted punch shall receive a Major Penalty. All other players except the goaltender shall immediately retire to the front of their respective benches during a fight.

Rule 72 — Harassment of Officials

A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any player or team official who challenges or disputes an official's ruling or displays unsportsmanlike conduct. Persistent disputes result in a Misconduct, and further disputes result in a Game Misconduct. Any player or team official who intentionally strikes, trips, checks, holds, or pushes a Referee or Off-floor Official shall receive a Match Penalty.

Rule 73 — Head Butt

A Major Penalty and Gross Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who uses their head or helmet to cause harm or to impede an opponent.

Rule 74 — Head Contact

A Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who intentionally contacts an opponent's head, face, or neck with their stick or any part of the player's body or equipment.

Rule 75 — High Sticking

Carrying a stick above the normal height of the opponent's shoulder is prohibited. A High Stick penalty applies to any illegal contact to an opponent's body above the top of the shoulders, whether intentional or unintentional. A Minor, Double Minor, or Major Penalty shall be assessed at the Referee's discretion. Any player who draws blood during a high stick shall be assessed a Minor, Double Minor, or Major Penalty.

★ **NBHL RULE** If a player makes contact with the ball over their shoulder it will be deemed a high stick and the offending team will lose a zone.

Rule 76 — Holding

A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to a player who holds an opponent with hands, legs, feet, stick, or in any other way.

Rule 77 — Hooking

A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any player who impedes or seeks to impede the progress of an opponent by using the blade or shaft of their stick.

Rule 78 — Interference

A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any player who: interferes with or impedes an opponent not in possession of the ball; deliberately knocks a stick out of an opponent's hand; prevents an opponent from regaining possession of their dropped stick; or interferes with the goaltender's movements. If an attacking player is in the goal crease when a goal is scored, the goal shall not be allowed unless the attacking player was physically interfered with by a defending player.

Rule 79 — Kneeing

A Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who intentionally knees an opponent during play or any altercation.

Rule 80 — Kicking

A Match Penalty shall be assessed to any player who kicks an opponent. If, at the Referee's discretion, a player unintentionally kicks another player in an attempt to free the ball, no penalty shall be assessed.

Rule 81 — Leaving the Bench

No player may leave the players' bench or penalty bench at any time during a fight, or for the purpose of starting a fight. Any player who leaves their bench during a fight shall incur an automatic Game Misconduct in addition to any other penalties. A player illegally entering the game who interferes with a player on a breakaway shall result in a Penalty Shot.

Rule 82 — Roughing

A Minor Penalty or, at the Referee's discretion, a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player guilty of unnecessary rough play or deliberate contact with an opposing player during play or after a stoppage.

Rule 83 — Slashing

A Minor Penalty or, at the Referee's discretion, a Major Penalty and Game Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who impedes or seeks to impede an opponent by slashing with their stick, or who swings their stick at an opponent (whether in range or not).

Rule 84 — Slew Foot

A slew foot is the act of hitting an opponent in their lower body with a foot, leg, or stick while simultaneously grabbing the opponent's upper body or head, causing them to fall. A Game Misconduct and Gross Misconduct shall be assessed to any player who attempts or completes a slew foot.

Rule 85 — Spitting

A Match Penalty shall be assessed to any player or Team Official who deliberately spits on or at an opponent, official, team official, or spectator.

Rule 86 — Spearing

A Major Penalty and Game Misconduct, or a Match Penalty at the Referee's discretion, shall be assessed to any player who spears or attempts to spear an opponent with the point of the stick blade.

Rule 87 — Third Man In

A Game Misconduct Penalty shall be assessed to the third player entering a fight already in progress. An automatic suspension shall also be assessed at the discretion of the Rules & Competition Committee.

Rule 88 — Throwing Stick or Object

When a stick or any object is thrown onto the playing surface by a player or team official, a Minor Penalty shall be assessed. If the thrown stick or object prevents a clear scoring chance, a Penalty Shot may be awarded. If the goaltender throws their stick, a goal shall be awarded.

Rule 89 — Tripping

A Minor Penalty shall be assessed to any player who places their stick, knee, foot, arm, hand, or elbow in such a manner that it causes their opponent to trip or fall.

Rule 90 — Verbal Slur / Obscene Gesture

A Game Misconduct Penalty shall be assessed to any player or team official who makes a verbal slur or obscene gesture of a racial, ethnic, religious, gender-based, or sexual orientation-based nature toward any person. At the Referee's discretion, a Gross Misconduct may be assessed.

SECTION EIGHT — NBHL-SPECIFIC RULES

The following rules apply exclusively to NBHL play and supersede the USA Ball Hockey Official Rule Book in all cases where there is a conflict.

8.1 Power Play in Overtime

★ **NBHL RULE** Power plays in OT go to 4-on-3. Once the penalty has expired, play continues as 4-on-4 until the next whistle, where it reverts back to 3-on-3.

8.2 Miscellaneous Game Rules

★ **NBHL RULE** There is no video review on any play.

★ **NBHL RULE** Any player found to be adjusting their stats incorrectly with intent to gain higher points will be suspended for 2 games.

8.3 Forfeits

A forfeit is recorded as a 3–0 win for the non-forfeiting team. An instance of forfeiture is defined as forfeits occurring within a single day.

★ **NBHL RULE** 1st instance of forfeiture: 1-game suspension for the Team Manager.

★ **NBHL RULE** 2nd instance of forfeiture: 2-game suspension for the Team Manager; team is ineligible for playoffs.

★ **NBHL RULE** If the Team Manager is not rostered, the team's Captain will be suspended. If no Captain is designated, the team's leading scorer will be suspended.

8.4 Zero Tolerance Policy

The NBHL maintains a zero tolerance policy for fighting, racism, and homophobia. All players are expected to uphold an inclusive and respectful environment.

★ **NBHL RULE** Any closed fist bare knuckle punch thrown will result in an automatic minimum 10-game suspension.

★ **NBHL RULE** Any form of hate speech or discriminatory behavior — verbal or physical — targeting someone's race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, or gender identity will result in the following suspension schedule:

- 1st offense: Minimum 2-game suspension.
- 2nd offense: 5-game suspension.
- 3rd offense: 10-game suspension.
- 4th offense: Lifetime ban.

SECTION NINE — CBHL-SPECIFIC RULES

The following rules apply exclusively to the Columbus Ball Hockey League (CBHL) and **supersede both** the USA Ball Hockey Official Rule Book and the NBHL-specific rules in all cases of conflict. CBHL rules are indicated with a ★ **CBHL RULE** marker.

9.1 — Player Pickup Rules (Minimum Roster)

CBHL Rule 9.1 — Pickup Players and Roster Minimums

★ **CBHL RULE** If a team has fewer than 7 players available at game time, they are permitted to pick up enough players from outside their roster to reach a total of 7.

★ **CBHL RULE** Once 7 players have been reached, only rostered players for the playing teams are allowed to join the game after it has started.

★ **CBHL RULE** If a team starts with fewer than 7 players, they may continue to pick up players as those players arrive at the rink, until the 7-player threshold is reached.

9.1.1 — Count Player Restrictions

A "Count" is defined as a player who is classified at a higher skill tier and whose participation may affect competitive balance. The following restrictions apply to Count players used as pickups:

★ **CBHL RULE** If a team already has 2 or more Count players participating, no additional Count players may join that team as pickups unless approved by the opposing team.

★ **CBHL RULE** If a team starts with fewer than 7 players and picks up players as they arrive, the Count rule remains in effect throughout the game. Any arriving player who is a Count must be approved by the opposing team before they may participate.

9.1.2 — Rostered Players Arriving Late

★ **CBHL RULE** If rostered players for a team arrive after the game has started, the same number of pickup (substitute) players must be removed from the game. The number of active players on the team may not exceed the number that would have been on the roster had all players arrived on time.

Example: A team starts with 5 players and picks up 2 substitutes to reach 7. If 2 rostered players arrive mid-game, those 2 substitutes must sit out for the remainder of the game.

9.2 — Game Times

CBHL Rule 9.2 — Game Start Times and Period Lengths

★ **CBHL RULE** Game start times and end times will be determined based on the number of teams playing and the total time allotted for games each night.

★ **CBHL RULE** Period lengths will be adjusted accordingly so that every game consists of three periods, regardless of the time slot. The three-period format is not negotiable.

★ **CBHL RULE** All game start times and period lengths will be communicated to the entire league in advance of each game night.

Note: Where adjusted period lengths conflict with the 10-minute period length specified under NBHL Rule 48 (Time of Game), this CBHL rule takes precedence.

9.3 — Icing

CBHL Rule 9.3 — Icing Definition and Application

★ **CBHL RULE** Icing occurs when a player shoots, bats with the hand or stick, or deflects the ball over the defensive zone blue line and the opposing team's goal line, in that order, and the ball remains untouched without scoring a goal.

This definition supersedes the clearing/icing rule described in Rule 36 and the NBHL icing line rule where there is any conflict. All other provisions of Rule 36 not in conflict with this definition — including no-line-change on icing, face-off dot selection, and icing exceptions — remain in effect.

9.4 — Overtime

CBHL Rule 9.4 — Overtime Format

★ **CBHL RULE** If a game is tied at the end of regulation, there will be one overtime period followed by a shootout if necessary. There are no additional overtime periods.

9.4.1 — Overtime Period

★ **CBHL RULE** Overtime is Sudden Death 3-on-3 play for a maximum of 3 minutes (running clock). The first team to score wins the game immediately. If no goal is scored during overtime, the game proceeds to a shootout.

Note: This rule supersedes the overtime formats described under NBHL Rule 47 (Tied Game / Overtime) for all CBHL regular season and playoff games.

9.4.2 — Shootout

★ **CBHL RULE** If the game remains tied after overtime, a shootout will determine the winner.

★ **CBHL RULE** Round 1 — Each team selects 3 different players to shoot. Each player takes one shot. The team with the most goals after all 3 shooters have gone wins the game.

★ **CBHL RULE** Sudden Death Rounds — If the score remains tied after Round 1, the shootout continues in sudden death rounds. Any player on the team may shoot, including players who were in the first three shooters. A player may shoot as many times as needed across as many rounds as needed until the game is won.

Note: This shootout format supersedes the NBHL shootout procedure described under NBHL Rule 47. The CBHL does not require both goalies to defend from the same net; standard shootout positioning applies unless otherwise communicated by the league.

9.4 — Penalty Clock Rules

CBHL Rule 9.5 — Clock Stoppage During Penalties

★ **CBHL RULE** If a period is being played with a running clock for any reason except a 6-goal differential, all penalties will be served on a stopped clock.

★ **CBHL RULE** If the clock is running due to a 6-goal differential (mercy rule), penalties will NOT stop the clock. The running clock continues uninterrupted regardless of any penalty assessed.

Note: The 6-goal differential mercy rule is defined under NBHL Rule 48 (Time of Game). This CBHL rule clarifies the specific interaction between the mercy rule clock and penalty time.